

The Golf Addict's Guide to Family Reintegration

An official programme for bringing him home
from the golf club, and keeping him there for
more than a few hours at a time.

Notice of issue

This programme has been issued because the people you live with have applied for your return.

The application followed a pattern. The pattern may involve Saturday mornings, Sunday mornings, Wednesday afternoons, the putt on the 7th, the state of the greens, the new committee, a golf bag in the downstairs loo and a quick nine that finished in the dark.

Receipt of this programme does not mean anybody is angry with you. Your first instinct to check whether it fits in your golf bag probably means somebody should be.

Keep the programme somewhere visible. Do not leave it in the boot of the car, in the side pocket of the bag with the tees and the broken pencils, or in the clubhouse, where it will be read aloud at the bar by a man called Keith.

Conditions of the programme

The Family Reintegration Programme offers household guidance only. It is not golf coaching, and it has no view on your grip. Keep playing golf if golf makes you happy. The Programme simply asks that you also come home.

Any resemblance to a golfer you know is entirely intentional in spirit and entirely accidental in every way a solicitor would care about.

No golf club, course, brand or professional player has approved this programme. Several would prefer you stayed exactly where you are.

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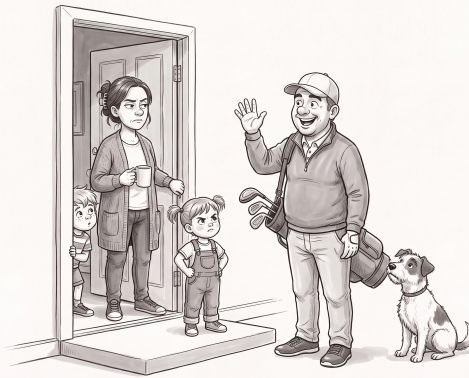
Stage Eight: Graduation

STAGE ONE

01

Arrival

Induction for household members returning from long-term golf.



Welcome home. Please leave your clubs at the front door. The front door, Dave. Not the downstairs loo, and not the boot of Sue's car, which she needs on Thursday.

STAGE ONE

In this stage you will be reintroduced to the people you live with, shown round the house, and asked to complete a short assessment of how far gone you are. Take your cap off for the photographs.

Why you are here

Your family has applied for your return. The application was not made lightly. It followed a review which found that you had spent 104 of the last 104 weekend mornings at the golf club, plus a number of Wednesday afternoons described to your employer as "working from home", and most of the rest of your time telling people about it.

Nobody is taking your clubs away. The Programme exists to rebuild the skills that lapsed during your long tour of duty on the course: answering a question with the answer to that question, turning up to things that have no tee time, and finding the kitchen without asking. These skills are still in there somewhere. Sue has seen them. She says they were last spotted on your honeymoon.

Your case sponsor is Sue. Sue has been married to you for eleven years, has two children under seven, and has heard about the putt on the 7th on roughly four hundred occasions, including once during a minute's silence. She will be keeping notes on your progress. You are not to read them, and you are certainly not to reply to them in the margin in pencil, as happened during the pilot scheme.

CASE NOTES (SUE), DAY 1

Said he'd be back by one. Back at twenty to seven. In that time I'd done swimming lessons, a birthday party and two meltdowns, one of them mine. I asked how his day was and got forty minutes, hole by hole. The 7th came up twice. He then asked what was for tea like it was a normal question. Bollocks to this, I'm having a bath.

The Programme runs in eight stages. Most participants complete it. A small number go out for a quick nine halfway through Stage Four and are next seen in the clubhouse in late October.

NO. 01 · ASSESSMENT

Initial assessment

Award yourself one point for each statement that is true.
Sue will check your answers.

- 1 You have gone out for "a quick nine" and come back in the dark. ☐

- 2 You have practised your swing with an umbrella in the queue at the post office, and the queue moved back. ☐

- 3 You know the date of next year's club medal, and not the date of your wedding anniversary. ☐

- 4 You checked the forecast for Saturday's tee time and did not notice it was also your daughter's fourth birthday party. ☐

- 5 There is a golf bag in the downstairs loo, and you consider this a storage solution. ☐

- 6 You have watched golf on the telly on a Sunday afternoon, having played golf all Sunday morning, and fallen asleep before the back nine. ☐

- 7 You have mentioned the 7th hole at a christening. ☐

- 8 You have shared your views on the new committee with somebody who is not a member of the club, such as the man who came to read the meter. ☐

- 9 You chose the family holiday in the Algarve because there "happened to be" a course nearby. There were three. You played all of them. ☐

- 10 You are reading this list and still think the 7th was a genuinely unlucky lip-out. ☐

SCORE / 10

Reading your score

0 to 2	3 to 6	7 to 9	10
You may have been sent this book by mistake. Please check you are in the right house.	Moderate. The Programme can help. Sue is cautiously optimistic, which is new for her.	Severe. Your family now refer to the club as "his other house", and the dog has stopped getting up when you come in.	For fuck's sake, Dave. Report to Stage One immediately, and leave the putter in the car.

Your household: a who's who

During your posting some members of the household have changed. Children have been born. One of them can now ride a bike without stabilisers, and you missed it. The dog is a different dog. Please study the following introductions before tea, so that nobody has to wear a name badge again.

Sue. Your wife and case sponsor. Five foot four, hair up in a clip, usually holding a cup of tea she made two hours ago and has not had a chance to drink. She does the school run, the swimming run, the party run and a part-time job. Sue knows your handicap to one decimal place against her will.

Alfie. Your son, six. Can ride a bike, swim a width and recite the offside rule. He calls the golf club "Daddy's work". Nobody has corrected him.

Poppy. Your daughter, four. She calls you Golf Daddy, which you took as a compliment. It was an observation.

The dog. Answers to Biscuit. Has chewed one of your gloves, which you still mention, and which Sue says was the happiest day of the dog's life.

NO. 02 · WORKSHEET

Who lives here?

Fill in the table without looking at the fridge, a phone or a Christmas card.

FAMILY MEMBER	NAME	AGE	SOMETHING THEY DID THIS YEAR
Your wife			
Your son			
Your daughter			
The dog			

If you have written "the little one" or "mate" in the name column, that counts as blank.

YOUR WELCOME PACK

On arrival you will be issued with the following. Tick each item once you have located it.

NO. 03 · CHECKLIST

Arrival kit

- ☐ One front door key. You have one already. It is on the keyring behind the ball marker.
- ☐ One map of the house, showing the kitchen, the washing machine and the room where the family sit in the evening.
- ☐ One calendar, showing family events in pen and golf in pencil.
- ☐ One pair of indoor shoes. They do not have spikes.
- ☐ One copy of this programme, which is not to be used to practise putting into a mug.

CASE NOTES (SUE), DAY 3

He asked where we keep the Calpol. At two in the morning. We've lived here six years.

STAGE TWO

02

Communication

Talking about something that is not your round, and listening to the answer.



The most common complaint the Programme receives concerns conversation. Households report that a returning golfer can turn any question, from "Did you pick up the milk?" to "How's your mum?", into a hole-by-hole account of the morning. This stage will teach you to hear a question, answer it, and ask one back.

How a question works

A question is a request for information. It usually has a short answer. When Sue asks, "How was your day?", she is asking for a general summary, roughly the length of a weather forecast. She is not asking for the 1st, the 2nd, the drive on the 3rd that "should have been a birdie chance", or the 7th.

The Programme recommends the following method. Hear the question. Give an answer of no more than two sentences. Ask a question back, and then listen to the answer to that question, even if it is about the neighbours' extension.

NO. 04 · QUIZ

What was the question?

For each question, circle the answer the family is looking for. 1. "How was your day?"

- ☐ a) "Good, thanks. How was yours?"
- ☐ b) "Well, I was one over through six, and then the 7th..."

2. "Did you remember the bread?"

- ☐ a) "Yes" or "No".
- ☐ b) "I nearly did, but Keith was on the practice green and you know what Keith's like about his takeaway."

3. "Mum's not been well."

- ☐ a) "Oh no. What's the matter?"
- ☐ b) "Sorry to hear that. Is she still in the same house? Because that's only ten minutes from the new course."

4. "What do you want for your birthday?"

- ☐ a) Something that is not a golf item.
- ☐ b) A new rangefinder.

If you circled any b), please read the method on the previous page aloud to the dog.

The putt on the 7th

The Programme is aware of the putt on the 7th. It was a six-foot putt, slightly downhill, with a left-to-right break that you read correctly. It was struck well. It lipped out. The Programme accepts that this was unlucky.

The Programme also notes that the putt was struck in May 2019.

Since then it has been described at two Christmases, one wedding, a hospital visiting hour, a christening and a parents' evening that you attended in place of Sue and at which you were not asked about golf. During this stage you are asked to stop telling the story of the putt. If you feel the story coming on, you may use the cut-out card below.

NO. 05 · CUT-OUT CARD

Emergency putt card

I AM ABOUT TO MENTION THE 7TH.

Instead, I will say: "Anyway, how are you?"

Keep this card in your wallet, next to the scorecard from 2019 that you also keep in your wallet.

Topics of conversation other than golf

Many returning golfers report that they no longer know what people talk about. Research carried out by the Programme with real households shows that families discuss the following, often for several minutes at a time and with nobody keeping score.

- Other people's holidays.
- What was on the telly last night, if it was not golf.
- Someone at work who has done something annoying.
- The price of things at the big Tesco compared with the small Tesco.
- Whether the car is making a noise.
- The children, in detail, including their reading books and who pushed who at nursery.

NO. 06 · WORKSHEET

Three minutes without golf

Choose a topic from the list. Talk about it with a member of the household for three minutes. Sue will time you. Mark each attempt below.

ATTEMPT	TOPIC	TIME BEFORE GOLF CAME UP
1		
2		
3		

A time of under forty seconds means golf came up in the first sentence and should be marked as a relapse.

Words that do not belong at the dinner table

The following words and phrases are for the clubhouse. Please leave them there.

SAID AT DINNER	WHAT THE FAMILY HEAR
"It was a tricky pin position."	"I'm about to talk for twenty minutes."
"I was robbed."	"I lost."
"Honestly, I was hitting it lovely."	"I lost badly."
"Keith's a sandbagger."	"Keith won."
"The greens were a disgrace."	"I'm going to write to the committee again."
"Just a quick one."	"See you at teatime."

CASE NOTES (SUE), DAY 9

Asked him what he thought of Alfie's swimming badge. He said "Not bad, not bad," then told me about Keith's handicap. He didn't know Alfie had been swimming. He's been going since March.

Listening

Listening is the other half of conversation. It involves staying quiet while another person talks, and not using that time to plan your next shot, check the club app, or practise your takeaway with the TV remote.

A good listener makes noises such as "Oh really?" and "What did she say to that?" A good listener does not say, "That's like what happened to me on the 7th." It was not like what happened to you on the 7th. Nothing is.

NO. 07 · CHECKLIST

Signs you are listening

Tick the signs you have shown this week.

- ☐ I looked at the person talking, not at the window to check the weather.

- ☐ I asked a follow-up question that did not involve golf.

- ☐ I remembered what I was told the next day.

- ☐ I did not put my phone face up on the table during the conversation.

- ☐ I did not swing anything while they were talking.

STAGE THREE

03

The Household

The garage, the lawn, the downstairs loo, and where the kitchen is.



While you were away the house carried on. Bins were put out, a boiler was replaced, and a new sofa arrived that you first noticed in March. This stage is a guided tour of the home you pay for, including the rooms you have only been in to look for your spare glove.

A tour of your home

The kitchen. The room with the kettle. Meals are made here, by somebody, every day. There is a dishwasher, which you may load. The cutlery basket goes in the bottom. Plates face the middle.

The living room. Where the family sit in the evening and talk. It contains a television, which also shows programmes that are not golf. There are four of these on at any one time.

The garden. A lawn with borders. It is not a practice green. The Programme has been made aware of the flag.

The downstairs loo. A toilet and a small sink. It is not a bag store, and a golf umbrella should not be propped behind the door, where it falls on guests.

The garage. Originally for a car. Now for golf. See the inventory on the next page.

NO. 08 · WORKSHEET

Garage inventory

Count and record the golf items in the garage. Then count the items that belong to anybody else.

ITEM	NUMBER
Golf bags	
Trolleys (including the electric one "for when my knee goes")	
Drivers, including ones you have "retired"	
Putters	
Buckets of practice balls	
Things belonging to anyone else in the family	

If the last line is lower than the number of putters, please read on.

The putter situation

The Programme acknowledges that a golfer needs a putter. The Programme's research shows that most golfers need one putter. Dave has eleven. Three of them are in the garage, two are in the car, one is behind the sofa, one is in the downstairs loo, one is "at Keith's", and three are unaccounted for. He is still looking for "the right one". Sue suspects the right one is the one he bought for £240 in 2017, used twice, and put in the loft.

The Programme does not ask you to throw any of them away. It asks you to choose two and store the others somewhere that is not the house.

HOUSEHOLD JOBS

During your posting the following jobs were done by other people. The Programme would like you to learn them in order of difficulty.

NO. 09 · CHECKLIST

Jobs I can do

Tick each job you have done since arriving. Sue will countersign.

- ☐ Put the bins out on the right night.

- ☐ Loaded the dishwasher without being told how afterwards.

- ☐ Mowed the lawn without mowing a green into the middle of it.

- ☐ Hoovered, including under things.

- ☐ Rung the man about the gutter.

- ☐ Cooked a meal that was not a barbecue.

- ☐ Done bath time and bedtime on my own, including the second story and the glass of water.

- ☐ Changed a duvet cover without getting inside it.

COUNTERSIGNED (SUE)

The lawn

The Programme has received a separate complaint about the lawn.

It is understood that over the summer the rear lawn was mown shorter in a circle near the patio, a hole was cut, and a small flag on a pole was inserted. It is further understood that the flag was a present from Keith. Sue describes the garden as "a pitch and putt with a rotary washing line", and the children have been told the flag is a no-go area. Poppy has been told off twice for moving it.

The flag is to be removed and returned to Keith. The circle may grow back in its own time. The children may now play anywhere, including on the green.

CASE NOTES (SUE), DAY 16

He mowed the lawn. The whole lawn. Then he stood at the kitchen window for twenty minutes looking at the stripes like he'd painted the Sistine Chapel. I'll take it.

Swinging household objects

Returning golfers are known to swing whatever they are holding. The Programme's records include an umbrella at a bus stop, a rolled-up Sunday paper in the lounge, a French stick at a family meal, and the barbecue tongs, which hit a lampshade.

The swing is often done without the golfer noticing. It is a half-swing, stopping at the top, with a small look down the imaginary fairway. It is usually followed by a nod.

NO. 10 · TRACKER

Swing log

Keep a record of every household swing this week. Sue will add any you miss.

DAY	OBJECT SWUNG	WHERE	ANYONE HIT?
Monday			
Tuesday			
Wednesday			
Thursday			
Friday			
Saturday			
Sunday			

STAGE FOUR

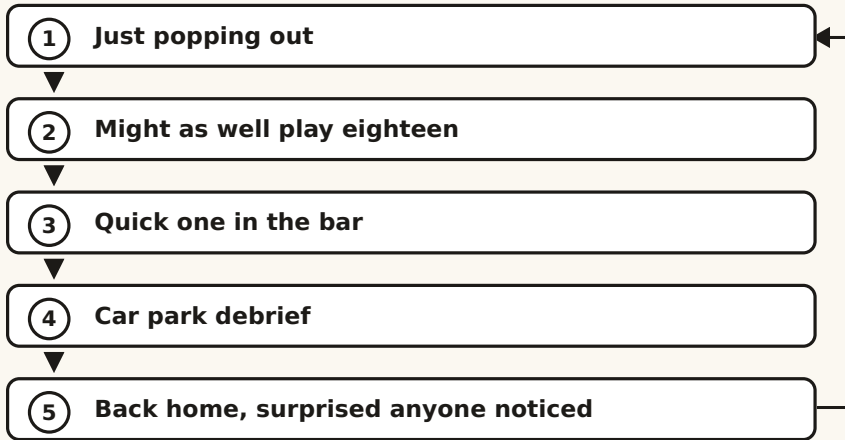
04 Time

What "a quick nine" means to everybody else, and how to read a calendar that is not the fixture list.



Golf time runs at a different speed from family time. A round that feels like three hours to you has lasted most of a day for the people at home. This stage is about the gap between the two, and how to close it.

The quick nine



"I'm just popping out for a quick nine" is the most common sentence in the Programme's files. Research shows that it is also the least accurate.

A quick nine is described by the golfer as an hour and a half. In practice it includes a drive to the club, a coffee, a chat in the car park, a warm-up on the range "to loosen off", a four-ball ahead that is "an absolute joke", nine holes, the decision to play "the back nine as well, seeing as we're out", a pint, a second pint because Keith is buying, and a debrief in the car park. Then the drive home.

NO. 11 · TABLE

Golf time conversion chart

Use this chart to translate what you say into what the family can expect.

WHAT YOU SAY	WHAT IT MEANS
"Quick nine."	Five hours.
"Back by one."	Back by teatime.
"Just hitting a few balls."	Three hours and a new driver.
"I'll be back before it gets dark."	You will not.
"Just one drink after."	Three. Somebody will give you a lift.
"I'll only be ten minutes, I just need to drop something off at the club."	Out for the afternoon.

Keep this chart on the fridge, where the whole family can use it.

Reading the family calendar

The house has a calendar. It hangs in the kitchen and has been filled in by Sue since the day you moved in. You may not have seen it, because your own calendar is the fixture list, which you keep in your head and on the back of the clubhouse door.

The family calendar contains birthdays, anniversaries, appointments, visits, school events and things marked simply "DAVE: DO NOT BOOK GOLF". These are not suggestions. The Programme recommends that you look at the family calendar before you look at the fixture list, and not the other way round.

NO. 12 · WORKSHEET

Which comes first?

For each pair of dates, tick the one that matters more.
There is a right answer each time.

OPTION A	OPTION B
☐ Your wedding anniversary	☐ The midweek medal
☐ Your son's first nativity play	☐ A fourball with Keith
☐ Your daughter's first day at nursery	☐ The midweek stableford
☐ Sue's fortieth birthday	☐ The club championship semi-final

If you ticked any box in column B, please see Stage Seven early.

The weather forecast

Most people check the weather to know whether to take a coat. You check it to know whether Saturday is on. The Programme has found that you are able to name the wind speed at 8am on Saturday to within two miles per hour, but you did not know it was due to rain at your daughter's fourth birthday party, and fourteen four-year-olds had to have it in the conservatory.

During this stage please check the forecast for family events as well. You will find that it is the same forecast.

CASE NOTES (SUE), DAY 22

He said he'd be back by one. He was back by one. I looked at the clock, then at him, then at the clock. He'd forgotten his wallet. Went straight back out.

NO. 13 · TRACKER

Seven-day time audit

For one week, write down what you said and what really happened. Sue will fill in the right-hand column.

DAY	WHAT I SAID	TIME I SAID	TIME I GOT BACK
Monday			
Tuesday			
Wednesday			
Thursday			
Friday			
Saturday			
Sunday			

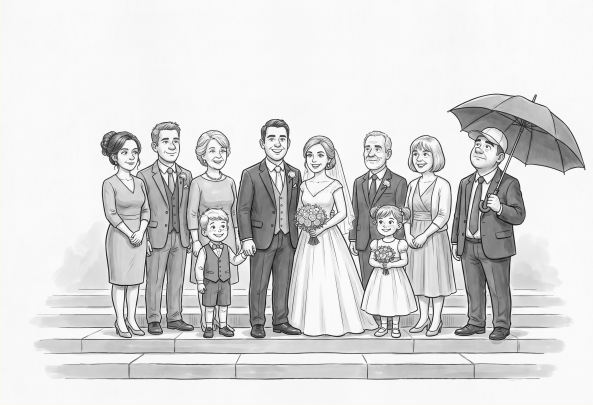
Total hours missing

STAGE FIVE

05

Family Occasions

Birthdays, anniversaries, school sports day, and a wedding on medal day.



Families have occasions. They are arranged weeks, sometimes months, in advance. Nobody checks them against the fixture list. This stage prepares you to attend them, in full, in person, and in shoes without spikes.

Attending an occasion

Attending means being there from the start to the finish. It does not mean arriving late "from the club", with grass on your trousers, in time for the cake. It does not mean leaving early "to catch the last few holes of the golf" on your phone, which you then watch in the car park.

When you attend an occasion please leave your phone in your pocket. The club results will still be there later. Keith's score will still be annoying.

Occasion guidance

Birthdays. Give a present that is not golf-related, and has not come from the pro shop. A voucher for the pro shop is still the pro shop.

Anniversaries. Remember them. The date is in the family calendar, circled, with the word "ANNIVERSARY" and three exclamation marks. You will find it easier to remember if you think of it as a major.

School events. Sports day, nativity plays, parents' evenings. Stand with the other parents and grandparents. Do not assess the egg and spoon race for technique.

Weddings. Attend the ceremony, the meal and the speeches. Do not ask the best man his handicap. Do not refer to the church as "a par four from the car park".

Funerals. No golf. None. Not even if the deceased "would have loved to know" about the new clubhouse.

NO. 14 · ASSESSMENT

Occasion readiness

Tick each statement that is true.

- ☐ I know the date of my wife's birthday without looking it up.
- ☐ I know the date of my wedding anniversary without looking it up.
- ☐ I have attended a family event from beginning to end in the last year.
- ☐ I have given a present that was not golf equipment.
- ☐ I have not checked the golf scores on my phone during a speech.
- ☐ I have not described an event as "a bit of a slow round".

SCORE / 6

A score of 3 or less means you are not yet ready to attend unsupervised.

Case study: Claire's wedding

Sue's sister Claire got married on the second Saturday in June. The date was set a year in advance. Alfie was a page boy and Poppy was a flower girl. Dave was an usher. He was told the date, and the date was put in the family calendar in red pen and underlined twice.

In February the club announced that the summer medal would also be on the second Saturday in June.

Dave's first words were, "Can't they move it?" It is not clear whether he meant the medal or the wedding. He then asked whether the wedding might start later, "just in case", and whether the reception was "near anywhere". Sue took him into the kitchen and closed the door. The family heard very little, except for one word, which was repeated several times.

Dave attended the wedding. He handed out the orders of service, he stopped Alfie eating the confetti, and at the reception he danced with Poppy standing on his shoes for the whole of the first song. He made one golf reference all day, a joke to the best man about how long it took him to get to the church, and everybody laughed, including Claire. The Programme records this as a success.

CASE NOTES (SUE), DAY 30

Claire sent round the wedding photos. He said "Lovely." Then he said "Is that me with the umbrella?" and went quiet. I think it got to him. I'm not saying anything.

NO. 15 · WORKSHEET

Family dates

Fill in the dates below. Then add them to your phone, next to the fixtures.

OCCASION	DATE
My wife's birthday	
Our wedding anniversary	
My son's birthday	
My daughter's birthday	
The dog's birthday (approximately)	

Presents that are not golf

The Programme has compiled a short list of presents that are suitable for family members. None of them are sold in a pro shop.

- Flowers, from a shop, not the clubhouse raffle.
- A meal out at a restaurant that is not in a golf club.
- A weekend away somewhere without a course. The Programme accepts that this will take some research.
- Tickets for something your wife wants to see, which you will also attend.
- Your time, given willingly, on a Saturday.

STAGE SIX

06

Holidays

Choosing a destination for reasons other than the courses.



A holiday is a period of rest taken by the whole family. The Programme has found that returning golfers treat holidays as an away fixture. This stage explains how to choose, book and survive a family holiday where golf is not the reason for going.

How holidays used to be chosen

The Programme has examined the last seven family holidays. Five were within a short drive of at least one golf course. Dave says this was "a coincidence". The villa in the Algarve was near three courses. The cottage in Scotland was on one. The weekend in Wales was booked because Dave "fancied the coast", and the coast turned out to be a links course.

The remaining two holidays were chosen by Sue. On one of them Dave found a pitch and putt.

NO. 16 · QUIZ

Why are we going there?

Look at the reasons below. Tick the ones that are acceptable reasons for choosing a family holiday.

- ☐ The weather is nice.

- ☐ The family have always wanted to go.

- ☐ There is a beach and a kids' club.

- ☐ It is near a course that "has had some really good reviews".

- ☐ The villa is "only twenty minutes from three championship courses".

- ☐ Keith went last year and got a hole in one.

If you ticked any of the last three, you have not understood the question.

Packing

Returning golfers pack as follows: clubs first, then golf shoes, then golf clothing, then golf balls, then whatever fits in the space left over, which is usually a pair of pants and a toothbrush.

For the family holiday the Programme recommends the reverse. Pack clothes for the whole week first. Then the sun-cream. Then something to read. If there is still space, it can stay empty.

NO. 17 · CHECKLIST

The family holiday packing list

- ☐ Clothes for a week, including something smart for a meal out.

- ☐ Swimming shorts.

- ☐ Suncream, for your whole face, not just the part under the cap.

- ☐ Something to read that is not a golf magazine.

- ☐ Buckets and spades, armbands, wet wipes, more wet wipes, and the tablet charger.

- ☐ A golf club (crossed out by Sue).

A week in Cornwall without clubs

This year the family went to Cornwall. The clubs were not packed. This was agreed in advance, in writing.

On the first day Dave walked on the beach and said the sand was "very fine", which the family understood was a comment on bunkers. On the second day he went to the shop for milk and came back two hours later having "had a look" at a course on the cliff. He did not play. He watched a four-ball putt out on the 18th and stood at the fence making small noises. On the third day he hired a putter for the crazy golf and lost to his son, who is six.

By the end of the week Dave had swum in the sea twice, eaten a pasty on the harbour wall, and been in all but one of the family photographs. The Programme records the week as a partial success.

CASE NOTES (SUE), DAY 38

Crazy golf. He lost to Alfie on the windmill hole and asked for a rematch. Alfie said no. Best thing I've seen all year.

NO. 18 · COMPARISON

Golf holiday or family holiday?

	GOLF HOLIDAY	FAMILY HOLIDAY
Getting up	6am, for the tee time	Twenty to six, because Poppy is awake
Lunch	A sandwich at the halfway hut	A long lunch with the family
Afternoon	The second round	The beach, the pool, a walk
Evening	Talking about the round in the bar	Dinner with the family, talking about anything else
Photographs	Scenic views of a fairway	Your family
What you remember	Your score on the 14th	Your son beating you at crazy golf

STAGE SEVEN

07

Relapse Prevention

Triggers, warning signs and a plan for the first sunny Saturday in April.



STAGE SEVEN

By this stage most participants have made progress. They have attended a family occasion, mown a lawn and spoken for three minutes without mentioning the 7th. This progress is fragile. It can be undone by one sunny weekend, a text from Keith or the arrival of the new season fixture list. This stage is about recognising the danger in time.

Your triggers

A trigger is anything that makes you want to go to the golf club when you are supposed to be at home. The Programme has identified the most common ones.

- A clear forecast for the weekend.
- A text from Keith that says "You out Saturday?"
- The clocks going forward in spring.
- Golf on the telly, especially the big tournaments, and anything with Americans shouting.
- A new driver that "everyone at the club" has.
- The words "I'm taking the kids to my mum's this weekend, so you're free to do what you like."

NO. 19 · WORKSHEET

My triggers

Write down your top three triggers and one thing you can do instead of going to the club.

MY TRIGGER	WHAT I WILL DO INSTEAD

"Go to the range instead" does not count as something to do instead.

Warning signs

Relapse rarely comes all at once. It builds up over several days. Families report the following warning signs.

- You begin checking the forecast more than twice a day.
- You mention the 7th again, "just in passing".
- You start leaving the car boot open "to air the clubs".
- You say "I'm not bothered about golf this weekend" twice, unprompted.
- You look at the lawn in a certain way.
- You describe the dog's walk as "a quick nine".

NO. 20 · CHECKLIST

Early warning signs this week

Tick any sign you have shown. Two or more means Sue will speak to you.

- ☐ Checked the forecast more than twice a day.
- ☐ Mentioned the 7th.
- ☐ Watched golf on the telly for more than two hours.
- ☐ Practised a swing with a household object.
- ☐ Bought something golf-related "that was on offer".
- ☐ Gone quiet during a conversation, and then said a word such as "birdie".

The first sunny Saturday in April

Every returning golfer knows this day. The clocks have gone forward. The grass is growing. The forecast is clear and dry, with light winds from the south-west. Your phone buzzes at 7am with a message from Keith containing only the word "Well?"

The Programme's advice is not to pretend this day does not exist. Plan for it. Agree a time with the family in advance. Play nine holes, and nine holes only. Be home when you said you would be home. Then spend the afternoon with your family, doing whatever they want to do, without looking at the sky.

NO. 21 · WORKSHEET

My sunny Saturday plan

QUESTION	MY ANSWER
What time will I leave?	
How many holes will I play?	
What time will I be home?	
What will I do with the family in the afternoon?	
Who will check I'm home on time?	Sue

SIGNED

WITNESSED (SUE)

Case study: the new driver

In March a new driver arrived at the club. It was bright, it was expensive, and everybody said it went twenty yards further. Dave said he "wasn't interested". He said this four times in one evening.

A week later a large parcel was delivered to the house while Dave was at work. Sue signed for it. It was long and thin and had a price on the invoice of £449. When Dave got home he said it was "a present for Keith". Keith's birthday is in November.

The driver is now in the garage with the others. Dave says it does go twenty yards further, "when I catch it right". He has caught it right once. The Programme records this as a relapse, and Sue records it as the kitchen extension being put back a year.

CASE NOTES (SUE), DAY 45

Four hundred and forty-nine pounds. For a stick. He said it was "an investment". I said "In what?" He's gone very quiet. Good.

NO. 22 · TRACKER

Relapse diary

Record any relapse this week, and how you made it up to the family.

DAY	WHAT HAPPENED	HOW I MADE IT UP

Keith

The Programme wishes to say a word about Keith.

Keith is a member of your four-ball. He has a handicap of eighteen and plays off twelve. He is retired, lives on his own, and is at the club seven days a week. He has no one at home who has applied for his return. Keith is a nice man, and a high-risk contact.

The Programme recommends that you limit your contact with Keith during reintegration to one round a week and do not reply to messages from him sent after 9pm, which usually say "Early one tomorrow?"

STAGE EIGHT

08

Graduation

The final assessment, and the Certificate of Reintegration.



STAGE EIGHT

You have reached the final stage. You have learned to answer a question, find the kitchen, read a calendar and survive a week in Cornwall. It is now time to be assessed. If you pass, you will receive a certificate. If you do not pass, you will go back to Stage One and Sue will make you a cup of tea while you do it, because she is kinder than the Programme.

NO. 23 · ASSESSMENT

Final assessment

Award yourself one point for each statement that is true. Sue will check your answers, and has already checked them.

- 1 When asked "How was your day?" you answered in two sentences and asked a question back. ☐
- 2 You have not mentioned the 7th in two weeks. ☐
- 3 The golf bag is no longer in the downstairs loo. ☐
- 4 You mowed the lawn and there is no flag in it. ☐
- 5 You have attended a family occasion from beginning to end. ☐
- 6 You said "back by one" and were back by one. ☐
- 7 You know the date of your wedding anniversary without looking. ☐
- 8 You went on a family holiday that was not chosen for the courses. ☐
- 9 You got through a sunny Saturday in April and were home when you said you would be. ☐
- 10 You have handed the barbecue tongs to someone else without swinging them first. ☐

SCORE / 10

Reading your final score

9 or 10	6 to 8	3 to 5	0 to 2
Graduate. Please proceed to your certificate.	Nearly there. You may take the certificate home, but Sue will keep it in a drawer until you have been back by one for a month.	Return to Stage Four. Take the conversion chart with you.	Dave, love. Put the bloody putter down and come and have your tea.

The final exam

As part of graduation you are asked to take part in one final exercise, carried out in front of the whole family at Sunday dinner.

Sue will ask you, "How was your round?" You will answer it in one sentence. The family will then ask you about the putt on the 7th, on purpose, as a test.

You may begin the story. The family will finish it for you. They know it word for word: six feet, slightly downhill, left to right, read it perfectly, struck it lovely, lipped out. They will say "lipped out" all together, as one. Then they will laugh, and you will laugh too, and that will be the last time the putt on the 7th is mentioned in this house.

The Programme expects it will be mentioned again on Boxing Day.

CASE NOTES (SUE), DAY 60

Sunday dinner. He started on the 7th and we all joined in and finished it for him. Alfie cried laughing. He doesn't even know what a lip-out is. Dave did too. Then he helped with the washing up and asked me about my week, and listened. I'll give him his certificate. He's still a daft sod.

NO. 24 · WORKSHEET

Promises

Write three promises to your family, to keep after the Programme ends. Sue will put this page on the fridge.

SIGNED

DATE

A final word from the Programme

The Programme would like to thank you for taking part. Nobody expected you to give up golf, and nobody wanted you to. Your family applied for your return because they missed you, and the golf was only ever the thing that kept you out until teatime.

Go and play your Saturday round. Enjoy it. Then come home when you said you would, sit down at the table, and ask somebody else how their day was.

Certificate of Reintegration

This is to certify that

has successfully completed the Family Reintegration Programme, and is hereby readmitted to the household as a full member, weekends included, subject to the fixture list.

He has learned to answer a question, to find the kitchen, to read a calendar and to be back by one.

He is permitted to mention the putt on the 7th once a year, on Boxing Day, for no longer than two minutes.

SIGNED (CASE SPONSOR)

SIGNED (PARTICIPANT)

DATE

About this programme

The Family Reintegration Programme was written for every family that has lost a Saturday to a quick nine, and for every golfer who has come home and said, "You'll never guess what happened on the 7th."

We guessed. We love you anyway.